

Henry Hetherington

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Henry Hetherington was born in 1792 in Compton Street, Soho. He was the son of a tailor. In 1805, he was apprenticed to Luke Hansard, the printer of the Journals of the House of Commons. When his apprenticeship ended and work was hard to find, he went to Belgium for 3 years. On his return, he worked as a shopman for Richard Carlile.

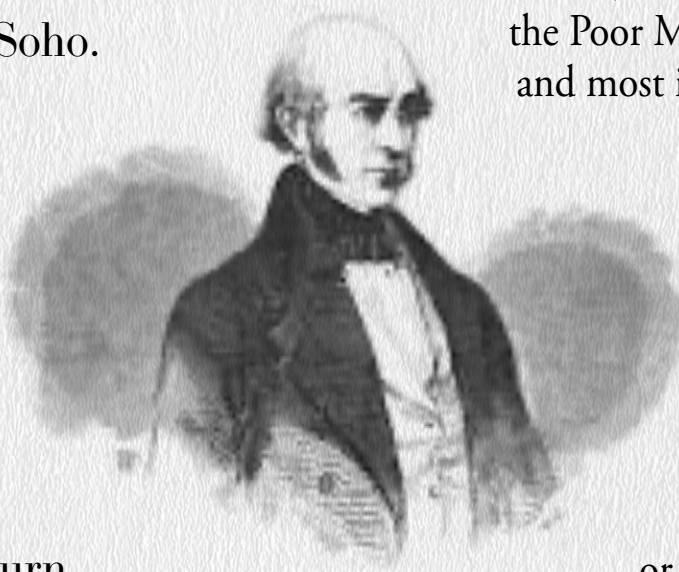
During the 1820s, he started his own printing and publishing business and joined several radical organisations. In 1820, he attended lectures on the co-operative ideas of Robert Owen, and became a founder member of the Co-operative and Economic Society.

In 1822 he set up his own press in Kingsgate Street, Holborn, paying a rent of £55 a year for the house. Here he published the Political Economist and Universal Philanthropist.

He next joined the London Mechanics Institute in Chancery Lane, founded in 1828 by George Birkbeck to provide adult education for working men. He joined the First London Co-Operative Trading Association. Hetherington and others then founded the British Association for the Promotion of Co-operative Knowledge. He became its most accomplished speaker, but a rift developed with Robert Owen, who thought politics were irrelevant to the growth of co-operation.

During the 1830s, Hetherington's main focus was universal suffrage and the demand for a free press. He joined several short-lived radical associations, including the Radical Reform Association, founded by Henry 'Orator' Hunt.

Henry Hetherington was a leading light in the "War of the Unstamped". The Government attempted to shut down radical newspapers by imposing a Newspaper Stamp Tax and increasing the paper tax. In the 1820s, radical papers decided to pay the tax, which at 4d was a multiple of the cover price, so circulation fell sharply. Readership was less affected, as people shared copies.



In 1831, Henry Hetherington began publishing the Poor Man's Guardian, the best-known and most influential of the many short-lived radical newspapers of the period. He appointed an editor so that he could concentrate on travelling, addressing public meetings, and expanding distribution.

The Great Reform Act of 1832 is known mainly for abolishing the "rotten boroughs", which returned one or two Members of Parliament despite having few electors. At the time, it was widely regarded as a betrayal, since only the middle classes gained the vote while the working classes remained excluded.

Although the Guardian lasted only 4½ years, its campaign against the newspaper tax, described as "a tax on knowledge", was a notable success. It showed there was a great demand for cheap newspapers and that radical ideas for voting reform attracted widespread support among the working classes. Its circulation was higher than all but one of the broadsheet newspapers. The Guardian also raised money through its Victims Fund to support working-class causes, including the Tolpuddle Martyrs and parish martyrs whose property was confiscated for refusing to pay church tithes.

Henry Hetherington was imprisoned three times during the War of the Unstamped; 800 other people were imprisoned for distributing unstamped papers. In 1836, the Government reduced the stamp duty from 4d to 1d and greatly increased the penalties for non-compliance. Hetherington's papers were converted to pay the stamp; he explained that "personal courage was useless against the government's new powers".

His activities paved the way for Chartism, which later divided into the "moral-force" and "physical-force" wings. The movement succeeded in presenting a huge petition to Parliament for votes and political reform, but thereafter lost momentum.

Hetherington remained active in public causes until he caught cholera in 1849. He refused medication in the belief that his lifelong teetotalism would protect him; he died in August.